

Uninvited Guest

One rainy day, a **holy** man knocked at the door of the **stingiest** couple in the village. The couple had just sat down to a **frugal** meal of cucumbers and they were not at all **pleased** to be disturbed. However, you cannot ignore a knock on your door so the husband went and opened it.

The holy man came in.

"So kind of you to invite me in," he said. "I'm **drenched**."

As the couple watched **open-mouthed**, he **took off** his kurta, **wrung** the water **out** of it and hung it on a nail in the wall.

"We were just about to eat," said the husband. "You can join us if you wish but as you can see we really don't have enough for three."

"You go ahead with your meal," said the holy man. "Don't **mind** me. I'll just take a cucumber."

Before the couple could say anything he picked up a cucumber from the table and began to eat. There were only three cucumbers left. The host quickly picked up two for himself and his wife picked up the remaining one.

"Very good, very good," said the holy man, **munching** noisily. "Needs a little salt, though."

"We're out of salt," said the woman, **tersely**.

"I've finished, anyway," said the holy man. "Best meal I've had in a long time. Well, the rain seems to have stopped and I must be on my way."

The couple **heaved a sigh of relief**.

"As you have been so good to me," said the guest, pulling on his kurta, "I will grant you three wishes."

"Three wishes!" **gasped** the man.

He **prostrated** and caught hold of the man's feet.

"Give me the golden touch," he **pleaded**. "Anything I touch, should turn to gold."



"Please **let go** of my feet, first," said the holy man, **backing away**. "I grant you your wish."

The man touched a pot and it turned to gold. He touched a chair and it turned to gold. He began to rush around the house, touching everything.

"For my wish," said the wife, prostrating and touching the holy man's feet, "I want that everything I touch should become long. You saw how small the cucumbers were. If I could make them long, my husband and I would never have to go half-hungry again."

"Let go of my feet, first," said the holy man. "As for your wish, well, you can have it."

The woman got up and touched a tiny green chilli lying on the table. Instantly it became a metre long. Her **squeal of delight woke up** their **infant** son who was sleeping in a **cradle**.

"Hush, my little raja," said the woman, and unthinkingly, touched his nose. Immediately it began to grow. Her **scream** brought her husband running to the spot. He picked up the baby and found that he was holding a golden statue.

"I want my baby, please give me back my baby," said the woman to the holy man.

"I can bring him back to life," said the holy man. "But if I do, both of you will lose your powers."

"That doesn't matter," said the woman.

Hardly had the words left her mouth than everything that had been turned to gold, including the baby, **reverted** to its original **state**. The chilli and the baby's nose too became small again.

The woman hugged her baby with joy.

"Could I have a small part of my power back?" asked her husband, turning around to **address** the holy man. But he was no longer there. He had **vanished**.

"It was God himself," said his wife, "and we treated him so **shabbily**."

But her husband wasn't listening. He was touching and re-touching everything to see if anything turned to gold.

Vocabulary

1. **Holy** (adjective) – sacred, divine, blessed, spiritual, pious – पवित्र
2. **Stingy** (adjective) – miserly, tightfisted, cheap, penny-pinching, ungenerous – कंजूस
3. **Frugal** (adjective) – economical, thrifty, sparing, prudent, modest – मितव्ययी
4. **Please** (verb) – satisfy, delight, gratify, content, indulge – प्रसन्न करना
5. **Drenched** (adjective) – soaked, wet, saturated, dripping, sopping – भीगा हुआ
6. **Open-mouthed** (adjective) – astonished, amazed, shocked, stunned, agape – मुँह खुला का खुला रह जाना (आश्चर्य से)
7. **Take off** (phrasal verb) – remove, strip, shed, disrobe, pull off – उतारना
8. **Wring out** (phrasal verb) – squeeze, extract, twist, press, drain – निचोड़ना
9. **Mind** (verb) – object, care, notice, resent, bother – परवाह करना / आपत्ति करना
10. **Munch** (verb) – chew, gnaw, crunch, nibble, devour – चबाना
11. **Tersely** (adverb) – curtly, briefly, brusquely, bluntly, concisely – संक्षेप में / रखेपन से
12. **Heave a sigh of relief** (phrase) – relax, feel comforted, breathe easy, calm down, unwind – राहत की साँस लेना
13. **Gasp** (verb) – pant, exclaim, wheeze, catch breath, inhale sharply – हाँफना / आश्चर्य से बोल उठना
14. **Prostrate** (verb) – bow down, kneel, lie flat, grovel, surrender – साष्टांग दंडवत करना
15. **Plead** (verb) – beg, implore, appeal, entreat, request – विनती करना
16. **Let go** (phrase) – release, free, loosen, unhand, drop – छोड़ देना
17. **Back away** (phrasal verb) – retreat, withdraw, step back, move away, recoil – पीछे हटना
18. **Squeal** (noun) – shriek, scream, cry, yelp, screech – चीख / चिल्लाहट
19. **Delight** (noun) – joy, pleasure, happiness, bliss, glee – आनंद
20. **Wake up** (phrasal verb) – arise, awaken, rouse, stir, get up – जाग जाना
21. **Infant** (adjective) – baby, newborn, toddler, tiny, young – शिशु
22. **Cradle** (noun) – crib, cot, bassinet, bed, rocker – पालना

23. **Scream** (noun) – cry, shriek, yell, howl, wail
– चीख
24. **Hardly** (adverb) – barely, scarcely, almost
not, rarely, only just – मुश्किल से
25. **Revert** (verb) – return, go back, regress,
resume, relapse – लौटना / वापिस आना
26. **State** (noun) – condition, situation, form,
shape, status – स्थिति
27. **Address** (verb) – speak to, talk to, direct,
respond, refer – संबोधित करना
28. **Vanish** (verb) – disappear, fade, evaporate,
dissolve, go away – गायब हो जाना
29. **Shabbily** (adverb) – rudely, poorly,
ungraciously, disrespectfully, untidily – बुरे
ढंग से / अपमानजनक तरीके से

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